

Ethical Theories

Ethical Theories provide foundational principles that explain *why* certain actions are considered right or wrong (e.g., Utilitarianism, Deontology, Virtue Ethics, Justice Ethics).

1. Utilitarianism

Principle:

An action is morally right if it results in the greatest good (happiness or pleasure) for the greatest number of people.

Key Thinkers:

- **Jeremy Bentham**
- **John Stuart Mill Focus: Consequences** of actions.

Example:

A hospital has one liver donor and five patients needing different organs. The doctor considers sacrificing one healthy person to save five lives.

- **Utilitarian view:** Saving five lives creates more overall happiness, so it might be justified—even if it feels morally troubling.

Strengths:

- Tries to help the most people.
- Useful for making public rules and decisions.

Criticism:

- Might allow doing something cruel if it helps more people.
- Doesn't protect each person's rights fairly.

2. Deontology

Deontology means doing the right thing because it's a rule or duty, not because of what happens after. Some actions are always right or always wrong, no matter the result. You should follow the rules and do your duty.

Key Thinker:

- **Immanuel Kant**

Focus: Intentions and duties behind actions.

Example:

- You promised to help your friend with homework. Even if you're tired, deontology says you should keep your promise because it's the right thing to do.

Deontological view: Lying is always wrong, so you should not lie—even if telling the truth could harm your friend.

Strengths:

- Respects individual rights and moral integrity.
- Clear rules offer moral certainty.

Criticism:

- Too rigid—ignores context or consequences.
- Can result in moral conflicts between duties.

3. *Virtue Ethics*

Principle:

Virtue ethics is a type of moral philosophy that focuses on **character** and the **qualities** (virtues) that make a person good, rather than just rules or consequences.

Key Thinker:

- Aristotle

Focus: Character and moral development, not specific rules or outcomes.

Example:

- A **truth-teller** tells people about a company doing something wrong, like cheating or breaking rules, even if it means losing their job.

Virtue ethics view: The **truth-teller** shows courage and integrity, acting in line with good character.

Strengths:

- Focuses on becoming a better person and having good intentions.
- Can adapt to different situations because it looks at the context.

Criticisms:

- Doesn't always say exactly what to do in a certain situation.
- Different cultures may have different ideas about what counts as a virtue.

4. *Justice Ethics (Ethics of Justice)*

Principle:

Justice ethics is about **fairness**. It focuses on making sure that **everyone is treated equally**, and decisions are made based on **rules, rights, and fairness**.

Key Thinkers:

- John Rawls
- Robert Nozick (as a critic)

Focus: Fair distribution of rights, resources, and opportunities.

Example:

- Two workers doing the same job should get the **same pay**. Treating one unfairly is against justice ethics.

Justice ethics view: This policy helps create fairness by addressing past disadvantages.

Strengths:

- Promotes fairness, equality, and protection of rights.
- Important in social, political, and legal systems.

Criticism:

- Complex and abstract.
- Disagreements about what counts as —just or —fair.

5. Rights-Based Ethics

Rights-based ethics focuses on the basic rights of every person, like the right to life, freedom, and safety. Actions are judged based on whether they respect or violate these rights

This theory emphasizes **dignity, autonomy, and respect**, and often serves as a foundation for legal and human rights frameworks.

Core Principle

—Every person has certain **basic rights** (like the right to life, freedom, and privacy), and these rights **must be respected and protected**, no matter the outcome.

Key Concepts

1. Natural Rights

- These are rights we have **just because we are human**.
- Right to **life, freedom, and safety**.
- Associated with **John Locke**.

2. Legal Rights

- Rights given and protected by legal systems.
- Example: right to vote, right to a fair trial. **Key Thinkers**
- **John Locke** – Natural rights (life, liberty, property)
- **Thomas Jefferson** – —Unalienable Rights in the U.S. Declaration of Independence
- **Ronald Dworkin** – Rights as trumps over majority rule

Strengths of Rights-Based Ethics

- **Protects individual dignity and freedom**.
- Offers a **moral foundation for justice, law, and equality**.

- Clear and powerful in defending against oppression or harm.

Criticisms

- **Conflict of rights** – What if one person's rights clash with another's?
- Doesn't always offer clear guidance in **complex situations**.
- Can become **too individualistic**, neglecting the common good.

Ethical decision-making models

Ethical decision-making models provide frameworks to guide individuals and organizations in determining what is right or wrong in a particular situation. Two widely discussed models in ethics are **Consequentialism** and **Duty-Based Ethics**.

Here's an overview of these models:

1. Consequentialism

Consequentialism is an ethical theory that focuses on the **results** of actions. It says that an action is **right** if it brings the **most good** or the **least harm** to the **most people**. According to this model, the rightness or wrongness of an action is determined by its consequences, specifically focusing on the greatest benefit or the least harm for the most people.

Key Concepts:

- **Utilitarianism** is a main type of consequentialism. It says the best action is the one that brings the most **happiness** or **well-being**.
- It follows the idea of "**the greatest good for the greatest number**."
- Actions are judged by their **results**, not by whether the action itself seems good or bad.

Strengths:

- **Flexible:** Can change based on the situation and possible outcomes.
- **Practical:** Useful in areas like law, healthcare, and economics where results matter.
- **Focus on well-being:** Tries to increase happiness and reduce suffering for as many people as possible.

Weaknesses:

- **Moral dilemmas:** Sometimes it may support doing something harmful if it leads to a better result (like hurting one person to help many).
- **Hard to predict:** It's not always possible to know what all the outcomes will be, especially in the long run.
- **Ignores rights:** It may ignore individual rights or fairness if the final result is seen as good for more people.

Example:

If a hospital has only one ventilator and two patients — one young and one elderly — a **consequentialist** would choose to give the ventilator to the person who is more likely to **live longer** or **help society more** in the future. This is because the goal is to get the **best overall result** for the most people.

2. Duty-Based Ethics (Deontology)

Duty-based ethics (Deontology) is a moral theory that focuses on following rules or duties, not on the results of actions. It says some actions are always right or wrong, no matter what happens after. Deontologists believe that some actions are intrinsically right or wrong, and individuals have a duty to follow these moral rules.

Key Ideas:

- **Immanuel Kant** said we should follow rules that treat others with respect and could be followed by everyone.
- **Moral Absolutism** means some actions (like not lying or stealing) are always right or wrong, no matter the situation.
- Some actions have **intrinsic value**, meaning they are right or wrong by themselves, not because of the outcome.

Strengths:

- Gives **clear rules** on what is right and wrong.
- Focuses on **respecting people's rights** and treating everyone fairly.
- Helps people stay **morally strong** by doing what is right, even when it's hard.

Weaknesses:

- Can be **too strict** and not allow exceptions, even in difficult situations.
- Sometimes **duties can clash**, like telling the truth vs. keeping someone safe.
- Not always good at handling **real-life problems** where some flexibility is needed.

Example:

A person finds a lost wallet full of money. Even though they need the money, they return the wallet because **keeping it would be stealing**, and stealing is **always wrong**. They do the right thing **not for reward or outcome**, but because it's their **moral duty** to be honest.

Comparison of Consequentialism and Duty-Based Ethics:

Aspect	Consequentialism	Duty-Based Ethics (Deontology)
Focus	Outcomes and consequences of actions	Whether the action itself is right or wrong
Key Principle	Greatest good for the greatest number (Utilitarianism)	Follow moral rules or duties (e.g., Kant's Categorical Imperative)
Strengths	Practical, flexible, focuses on overall well-being	Clear rules, respects people's rights and fairness
Weaknesses	May allow harm if it leads to better results	Can be strict, ignores the situation or possible outcomes
Moral Dilemma Example	Sacrificing one to save many	Upholding duties like truth-telling or respect for rights

Moral reasoning

Moral reasoning is the process of thinking about what is **right or wrong, good or bad**, based on **ethical principles**. It helps people decide how to act in a fair and moral way by looking at the situation, the people involved, and what is **considered right in society**. Moral reasoning typically involves several stages or approaches, including:

1. **Consequentialist reasoning (Utilitarianism)**: Focusing on the outcomes of actions to determine if they are morally right or wrong (e.g., maximizing happiness or minimizing harm).
2. **Deontological reasoning**: Focusing on the adherence to rules, duties, or obligations rather than outcomes (e.g., telling the truth is right regardless of the consequences).
3. **Virtue ethics**: Focusing on the character and intentions of the person performing the action, asking whether the action reflects good moral character.

Important Skills for Ethical Reasoning

- ❑ **Moral Reasonableness** – the ability and willingness to be morally reasonable that one should have while dealing such issues. Unless one is willing and improve such ability, justice cannot be done.
- ❑ **Respect for Persons** – the persons involved in the issue, should be treated with genuine concern by one. Such concern should also be there with oneself along with being there for others.
- ❑ **Tolerance of diversity** – People have different backgrounds and beliefs. It's important to accept and respect these differences in moral thinking.
- ❑ **Moral hope** – Moral conflicts can be solved through open, honest, and fact-based communication that both sides accept.
- ❑ **Integrity** – the moral integrity has to be maintained. Being honest and having strong moral principles helps one to resolve an issue in an efficient manner. An individual also

needs to consider other's professional life and personal convictions while solving a problem.

An issue is a problem or topic that causes concern or disagreement and needs attention or a solution. Issues can happen in many areas like society, politics, personal life, or work. Issues can arise in various contexts, including social, political, personal, or professional domains.

Steps to Deal with Issues:

Whenever there occurs an issue, one should possess a few skills in order to sort out the problem. The issues that engineers face have to be dealt with patience and few moral goals have to be kept in mind while dealing with such issues. They are as follows –

- ❑ **Moral Awareness** – One should be able to recognize the moral problems and issues that occur in Engineering. The analysis on the problem is necessary in order to differentiate and judge according to ethics or according to the rules to follow.
- ❑ **Cogent Moral Reasoning** – In order to come to a conclusion on an issue, the argument has to be assessed and comprehended. The argument on both sides has to be considered with all the probabilities and the nature of the argument should be logical and moral.
- ❑ **Moral Coherence** – After having gone through all the logical and moral facts, consistent and comprehensive viewpoints are to be formed based upon a consideration of relevant facts.
- ❑ **Moral Imagination** – The moral issues and the practical issues have to be dealt separately. Alternative responses are to be found out for dealing with moral issues while creative solutions should be found out for practical difficulties.
- ❑ **Moral Communication** – The language to communicate about one's moral views should be so precise and clear, that the expression or words should not alter the original meaning.

Moral Issues:

A moral issue can be understood as an issue to be resolved not only by considering the technical stuff but also by keeping moral values in mind. To be more precise, let us consider the definition in general.

“Moral issue is a working definition of an issue of moral concern is presented as any issue with the potential to help or harm anyone, including oneself.”

Types of Moral Issues

There are mainly two types of Moral issues that we mostly come across while keeping the ethical aspects in mind to respond. They are –

- ❑ **Micro-ethics:** This focuses on small, everyday moral problems that individuals or companies face in their professional work, especially in engineering.
Example: An engineer deciding whether to report a safety issue in a machine.
- ❑ **Macro-ethics:** This approach deals with social problems which are unknown. However, these problems may unexpectedly face the heat at both regional and national levels. For example, global issues, collective responsibilities of groups such as professional societies and consumer groups.

Let us now understand a few examples related to moral issues.

Example 1

After a recent collapse of a structure in which many people died, an Engineer came to know about a bridge which is marginally safe. He informed his superior who asked him to stay calm and not to discuss with anyone, while waiting for the next year budget sessions to get some financial help for the repair required. What should the engineer do?

Example 2

What should an Engineer who observes his colleague copying confidential information unauthorized, do immediately? If he chooses to stop his friend, what if this gets repeated without his notice? If he chooses to report the management, what if his friend loses the job? Which is morally correct?

Example 3

An engineer, who develops a proto-type for the project, loses it due to a mishap exactly the day before the submission. Is it morally correct to outsource the prototype of the project and reduce the risks of job insecurity? What should he do?

These are the few examples just to understand the kind of moral dilemmas. There might be one or more correct answers at times. There can be some other way around to deal with the issue, which one can't easily notice. However, the decisions have to be made by following a slow and clear process in order to avoid further problems and also to solve this in a manner that leads to no regrets.

Moral Dilemma:

Dilemmas are situations in which moral reasons come into conflict, or in which the application of moral values are problems, and one is not clear of the immediate choice or solution of the problems. Moral reasons could be rights, duties, goods or obligations. These situations do not mean that things had gone wrong, but they only indicate the presence of moral complexity. This makes the decision-making complex. For example, a person promised to meet a friend and dine, but he must help his uncle who is involved in an accident — one has to fix the priority.

There are some difficulties in arriving at the solution to the problems, in dilemma. The three complex situations leading to moral dilemmas are:

1. **The problem of vagueness:** One is unable to distinguish between good and bad (right or wrong) principle. Good means an action that is obligatory. For example, code of ethics

specifies that one should obey the laws and follow standards. Refuse bribe or accept the gift, and maintain confidentiality

2. The problem of conflicting reasons: One is unable to choose between two good moral solutions. One has to fix priority, through knowledge or value system.

3. The problem of disagreement: There may be two or more solutions and none of them mandatory. These solutions may be better or worse in some respects but not in all aspects. One has to interpret, apply different morally reasons, and analyze and rank the decisions. Select the best suitable, under the existing and the most probable conditions.

Which of the following is a special case that justifies breaking a generally accepted rule?

1a. You should respect the Highway Code, but it is ok to drive through a red light if you are late for work.

1b. You should respect the Highway Code, but it is ok to drive through a red light if you are taking a critically ill person to the hospital.

2a. You should keep your word, but it is ok to break a social engagement if something more interesting comes up.

2b. You should keep your word, but it is ok to break a social engagement if you have just contracted an infectious disease.

3a. You should pay your taxes, but it is ok not to pay them if you are short of money that year.

3b. You should pay your taxes, but it is ok not to pay them if they are being spent on a nuclear arms program.

Example:

An elderly woman living alone in poor circumstances with few friends or relatives is dying, and you, her friend, are at her bedside. She draws your attention to a small case under her bed, which contains some mementos along with the money she has managed to save over the years, despite her apparent poverty. She asks you to take the case and to promise to deliver its contents, after she dies, to her nephew living in another state. Moved by her plight and by your affection for her, you promise to do as she requests. After a tearful goodbye, you take the case and leave. A few weeks later the old woman dies, and when you open the case, you discover that it contains \$500,000 dollars. No one else knows about the money, or the promise you made. You learn that the nephew is a compulsive gambler and has a drug addiction.

What would you do? Why?

Steps in Facing Moral Dilemmas

Whenever a person is faced with a moral dilemma, the issue is to be solved with a stepwise approach as this will generate a better output. The steps include the following –

❑ Identification

The step of identification involves the following – ■

The issue has to be thoroughly understood.

- The duties and the responsibilities of the persons involved are to be clearly known.
- The moral factors related to the issue are to be understood.
- The conflicting responsibilities, the competing rights and the clashing ideas involved are to be identified.

❑ Ranking

The considerations in the issue are to be listed down. Then they have to be ranked according to the priorities. The moral aspect has to be considered to rank the issues. The advantages of a single person should never be given any importance unless any moral reason is there behind it. No partiality is allowed.

❑ Inquiries

The inquiry of details involved in the issue is to be completely made. All the facts related to the issue are brought into light. Considering the alternative courses of action for resolving and tracing, full implications are also needed.

❑ Discussions

Discussions are to be made with other members, as different minds look at the issue in different views to give different solutions. The complete analysis of a problem gives chances to different viewpoints, perspectives and opinions from which a better solution can be drawn.

❑ Final Solution

After analyzing different perspectives and considering the facts and reasons on the basis of truths and understanding the flaws which lead to the issue, a final solution has to be drawn out. This solution will add value to the whole analysis, in all aspects.

What is a Moral Dilemma?

A moral dilemma is a situation where a person has to choose between two or more actions, and each choice has a moral reason behind it, but only one can be chosen. The problem is that no choice seems completely right or wrong, which makes it difficult to decide.

Step-by-Step Approach for Engineers to Resolve a Moral Dilemma:

Engineers can follow these structured steps to handle moral dilemmas ethically:

1. Identification

- Understand the issue fully.
- Know the duties and responsibilities of all involved.
- Identify the moral factors, conflicting rights, and responsibilities.

2. Ranking

- List all considerations involved in the issue.
- Rank them by priority based on moral importance, not personal gain.
- Ensure fairness and avoid partiality.

3. Inquiries

- Gather all relevant facts and details.
- Consider different courses of action and understand their consequences.

4. Discussions

- Discuss the issue with team members or experts.
- Multiple perspectives can help in analyzing the problem more effectively.

5. Final Solution

- After analyzing all viewpoints and facts, choose the best ethical solution.
- The solution should be based on truth, reasoning, and add value to the situation.

Example in Engineering Context:

An engineer detects a flaw in a construction project. Reporting it may delay the work and cost money, but not reporting it could risk public safety.

Using the above steps, the engineer should prioritize **safety and ethics** over cost or deadlines and take action accordingly.